

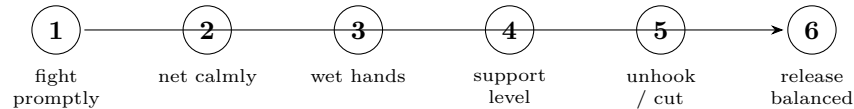
Handling & Release

ChatGPT edition

Prepare before the bite

Before casting

Match tackle to the largest plausible fish. Open pliers and cutters; wet and stage a knotless rubber net; decide whether the fish can be released beside the boat. Favor tackle that limits deep hooking when release is likely.



At the fish

1. Keep it in water when possible. Wet hands; never squeeze gills or eyes.
2. Support a large fish horizontally with two hands. Minimize air exposure; photograph only when tools and camera are already ready.
3. Back out an accessible hook. If deep extraction will prolong trauma, cut the line promptly; avoid stainless hooks where one may be left.
4. Return the fish when it maintains balance. Face it into gentle current only when present; do not pump it violently.

DEPTH AND TEMPERATURE

Deep capture and warm water increase risk. Wisconsin DNR does not recommend artificial swim-bladder deflation. Change location, depth, tackle or target rather than repeatedly producing fish unlikely to survive.

Source: Wisconsin DNR Catch-and-Release Guidelines.

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